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Per ***Executive Order 14434***, federal agencies are now using 'Super Intelligence' (SI) in place of 'Artificial Intelligence' (AI). You may see both terms across NIH content during this transition.

URL of this page: https://medlineplus.gov/druginfo/meds/a681004.html

Acetaminophen

pronounced as (a set a mee' noe fen)

Notice:

On September 22, 2025, the Food and Drug Administration (FDA), issued a safety warning indicating that taking acetaminophen while pregnant may be associated with the development of neurological conditions such as Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD) or Attention Hyperactivitiy Defecit Disorder (ADHD) in children. Although no evidence to date has been able to show that acetaminophen in pregnancy causes these disorders, some studies have shown an association. Talk to your doctor about the risks and benefits or using acetaminophen during pregnancy.

IMPORTANT WARNING:

Taking too much acetaminophen can cause liver damage, sometimes serious enough to require liver transplantation or cause death. You might accidentally take too much acetaminophen if you do not follow the directions on the prescription or package label carefully, or if you take more than one product that contains acetaminophen.

To be sure that you take acetaminophen safely, you should

- not take more than one product that contains acetaminophen at a time. Read the labels of all the prescription and nonprescription medications you are taking to see if they contain acetaminophen. Be aware that abbreviations such as APAP, AC, Acetaminophen, Acetaminoph, Acetaminop, Acetamin, or Acetam may be written on the label in place of the word acetaminophen. Ask your doctor or pharmacist for help determining if the product you are taking contains acetaminophen.

- take acetaminophen exactly as directed on the prescription or package label. Do not take more acetaminophen or take it more often than directed, even if you still have fever or pain.
- do not take more than 4000 mg of acetaminophen per day from all sources. Ask your doctor or pharmacist if you need help determining how much acetaminophen you can take.
- tell your doctor if you have or have ever had liver disease.
- not take acetaminophen if you drink three or more alcoholic drinks every day. Talk to your doctor about the safe use of alcohol while you are taking acetaminophen.
- stop taking your medication and call your doctor right away if you think you have taken too much acetaminophen, even if you feel well.

Talk to your pharmacist or doctor if you have questions about the safe use of acetaminophen or acetaminophen-containing products.

Why is this medication prescribed?

Acetaminophen is used to relieve mild to moderate pain and to reduce fever. Acetaminophen is in a class of medications called analgesics (pain relievers) and antipyretics (fever reducers). It works by changing the way the body senses pain and by cooling the body.

How should this medicine be used?

Acetaminophen comes as a tablet, chewable tablet, capsule, suspension or solution (liquid), extended-release (long-acting) tablet, and orally disintegrating tablet (tablet that dissolves quickly in the mouth), to take by mouth, with or without food. Acetaminophen is available without a prescription, but your doctor may prescribe acetaminophen to treat certain conditions. Take acetaminophen exactly as directed.

Follow the directions on the package or prescription label carefully. Do not take more than indicated on the label.

If you are giving acetaminophen to your child, read the package label carefully to make sure that it is the right product for the age of the child. Do not give children acetaminophen products that are made for adults. Check the package label to find out how much medication the child needs. If you know how much your child weighs, give the dose that matches that weight on the chart. If you don't know your child's weight, give the dose that matches your child's age. Ask your child's doctor if you don't know how much medication to give your child.

Acetaminophen comes in combination with other medications to treat cough and cold symptoms. Check nonprescription cough and cold product labels carefully before using two or more products at the same time. These products may contain the same active ingredient(s) and taking them together could cause you to receive an overdose.

Swallow the extended-release tablets whole; do not split, chew, crush, or dissolve them.

Place the orally disintegrating tablet ('Meltaways') in your mouth and allow it to dissolve, or chew it before swallowing.

Shake the suspension well before each use to mix the medication evenly. Always use the measuring cup or syringe provided by the manufacturer to measure each dose of the solution or suspension. Do not switch dosing devices between different products; always use the device that comes in the product packaging.

Stop taking acetaminophen and call your doctor if your symptoms get worse, you develop new or unexpected symptoms, including redness or swelling, your pain lasts for more than 10 days, or your fever gets worse or lasts more than 3 days. Also stop giving acetaminophen to your child and call your child's doctor if your child develops new symptoms, including redness or swelling, or if your child's pain lasts for longer than 5 days, or if a fever gets worse or lasts longer than 3 days.

Do not give acetaminophen to a child who has a sore throat that is severe or does not go away, or that occurs along with fever, headache, rash, nausea, or vomiting. Call the child's doctor right away, because these symptoms may be signs of a more serious condition.

Other uses for this medicine

Acetaminophen may also be used in combination with aspirin and caffeine to relieve the pain associated with migraine headache.

This medication is sometimes prescribed for other uses; ask your doctor or pharmacist for more information.

What special precautions should I follow?

Before taking acetaminophen,

- tell your doctor or pharmacist if you are allergic to this medication, any part of this medication, or any other medications, foods or substances. Tell your doctor or pharmacist about the allergy and what symptoms you had.
- tell your doctor and pharmacist what prescription and nonprescription medications, vitamins, nutritional supplements, or herbal products you are taking or plan to take while taking acetaminophen. Your doctor may need to change the doses of your medications or monitor you carefully for side effects.
- tell your doctor if you are pregnant, plan to become pregnant, or are breast-feeding. If you become pregnant while taking acetaminophen, call your doctor.
- you should know that combination acetaminophen products for cough and colds that contain nasal decongestants, antihistamines, cough suppressants, and expectorants should not be used in children younger than 2 years of age. Use of these medications in young children can cause serious and life-threatening effects or death. In children 2 through 11 years of age, combination cough and cold products should be used carefully and only according to the directions on the label.
- if you have phenylketonuria (PKU, an inherited condition in which a special diet must be followed to prevent damage to your brain that can cause severe intellectual disability), you should know that

some brands of acetaminophen chewable tablets may be sweetened with aspartame, a source of phenylalanine.

What special dietary instructions should I follow?

Unless your doctor tells you otherwise, continue your normal diet.

What should I do if I forget a dose?

This medication is usually taken as needed. If your doctor has told you to take acetaminophen regularly, take the missed dose as soon as you remember it. However, if it is almost time for the next dose, skip the missed dose and continue your regular dosing schedule. Do not take a double dose to make up for a missed one.

What side effects can this medication cause?

Acetaminophen may cause side effects.

Some side effects can be serious. If you experience any of the following symptoms, stop taking acetaminophen and call your doctor immediately or get emergency medical attention:

- red, peeling or blistering skin; rash; hives; itching; swelling of the face, throat, tongue, lips, hands, feet, ankles or lower legs; hoarseness; difficulty breathing or swallowing
- yellowing of the skin or whites of the eyes; upper belly pain; dark urine; pale stools

Acetaminophen may cause other side effects. Call your doctor if you have any unusual problems while you are taking this medication.

If you experience a serious side effect, you or your doctor may send a report to the Food and Drug Administration's (FDA) MedWatch Adverse Event Reporting program online (https://www.fda.gov/Safety/MedWatch [https://www.fda.gov/Safety/MedWatch]) or by phone (1-800-332-1088).

What should I know about storage and disposal of this medication?

Keep this medication in the container it came in, tightly closed, and out of reach of children. Store it at room temperature and away from excess heat and moisture (not in the bathroom).

Keep all medication out of sight and reach of children as many containers are not child-resistant. Always lock safety caps. Place the medication in a safe location – one that is up and away and out of their sight and reach. https://www.upandaway.org [https://www.upandaway.org]

Dispose of unneeded medications in a way so that pets, children, and other people cannot take them. Do not flush this medication down the toilet. Use a medicine take-back program. Talk to your pharmacist about take-back programs in your community. Visit the FDA's Safe Disposal of Medicines website https://goo.gl/c4Rm4p [https://goo.gl/c4Rm4p] for more information.

In case of emergency/overdose

In case of overdose, call the poison control helpline at 1-800-222-1222. Information is also available online at https://www.poisonhelp.org/help [https://www.poisonhelp.org/help] . If the victim has collapsed, had a seizure, has trouble breathing, or can't be awakened, immediately call emergency services at 911.

If someone takes more than the recommended dose of acetaminophen, get medical help immediately, even if the person does not have any symptoms. Symptoms of overdose may include the following:

- nausea, vomiting, loss of appetite; upper belly pain
- yellowing of the skin or eyes
- sweating
- extreme tiredness or flu-like symptoms
- unusual bleeding or bruising

What other information should I know?

Ask your pharmacist any questions you have about acetaminophen.

Keep a written list of all of the prescription and nonprescription (over-the-counter) medicines, vitamins, minerals, and dietary supplements you are taking. Bring this list with you each time you visit a doctor or if you are admitted to the hospital. You should carry the list with you in case of emergencies.

Brand names

- Actamin ® ¶
- Feverall ®

- Panadol ® ¶
- Tempra Quicklets ® ¶

- Tylenol ®

Brand names of combination products

- Dayquil ® (containing Acetaminophen, Dextromethorphan, Pseudoephedrine)

- NyQuil Cold/Flu Relief ® (containing Acetaminophen, Dextromethorphan, Doxylamine)

Other names

- APAP
- N-acetyl-para-aminophenol
- Paracetamol

¶ - This branded product is no longer on the market. Generic alternatives may be available.

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